Retrieval homework

Revisiting learning beyond the lesson

Use retrieval homework to revisit taught knowledge between lessons. Make the independent attempt possible, provide useful feedback and connect gaps to future teaching.

How to do it well

1 Select the retrieval content. Choose important taught knowledge and procedures, including planned returns to older topics.

2 Keep the task manageable. State the response, approximate scope and how students should act when stuck.

3 Protect the attempt. Give instructions to work independently before checking solutions or a support reference.

4 Build corrective feedback. Provide accurate explanations or worked solutions and a way to record consequential errors.

5 Connect to the next lesson. Recheck selected items, address common gaps and schedule further retrieval where needed.

What this sounds like

“Try these questions from memory first. Then use the worked solutions to identify errors. Bring one question you need to revisit; we will check the main decisions next lesson.”

Classroom example. A Science homework mixes taught calculations and older retrieval. Pupils attempt before checking worked solutions and record one error to revisit. The next lesson uses a pivotal related question to sample the learning. The homework supports retrieval and feedback rather than becoming independent discovery of a procedure students have never been taught.

Top tips that make the technique work

Use taught, accessible content. Homework should not rely on students discovering a new method without instruction.

Separate attempt and solution. Students need a chance to retrieve before checking worked answers.

Mix recent and older learning. A deliberate sequence strengthens return to important knowledge across time.

Provide a help route. A specific model, resource or reference supports students when recall fails.

Use the result in class. Sample a pivotal item or misconception so homework informs later retrieval and explanation.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Set homework through the current BSCS arrangements.	Untaught independent content as retrieval.
Use feedback and later retrieval.	Checking completion without attending to the learning.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

Barton — Homework